In another instance, he said: '… the manner in which Mr Ratan Tata made himself chairman of TELCO left a bitter taste in my mouth. That's when I realized that the young man wasn't as innocent as he looked.'

The TELCO episode was a big blow to the man who once said in an interview that many even called him a 'megalomaniac'. He had prided himself as someone who possessed the managerial skills that none of the other company heads did. His style was pompous and his statements boastful. That he piloted his own aircraft during his frequent trips around the country only added to the mystique around him. His flamboyance, his dandy dressing, the confident air with which he went about doing things, all became characteristic of the man.

But after the TELCO episode, things went downhill for Mody. The nearly five decades of relations with JRD that had afforded Mody the opportunity to enjoy a 'lifestyle' where he 'worked hard' and 'played hard' were lost with his inglorious exit some years later.

The consequences of Mody's miscalculations were far-reaching. It opened the path for Ratan to ascend the apex of the second-largest group company, TELCO.

But Ratan's journey in the driver's seat of the largest automobile manufacturer would be anything but smooth. It began on a very bumpy note, in a maelstrom of labour unrest that would test his resolve, strength, endurance and capacity to retain balance even in the face of highly volatile and provocative situations.